

Smart city initiatives and digitisation are making sweeping changes in the lives of citizens. The move is aimed at providing governance like never before. Digitisation and technology solutions have improved the speed of information exchange, enabling better administration. Smart city and digital governance are meant to improve the quality of life and living standards of citizens, and make public utilities seamlessly accessible to them. Here is how this can be done.

1. **Improved project management:**

A smart governance portal allows key decision makers to automate important reporting metrics for tracking projects. These decision makers will have all the critical information needed to take timely action for completing quality projects as per the schedule.

2. **Grievance management:** Good governance requires handling citizens' grievances and complaints with urgency. Quite often, administrators lack the necessary data metrics for tracking the execution of these grievances. But with digitisation, citizens can log their complaints through their mobile devices from any location. So, whether it is a water, electricity, transportation or housing problem grievance, all you need to do is log the complaint and track it online. Administrators can also get information about average time to service a citizen fault, best performing departments, departments with maximum pending complaints, etc. This information is necessary for improving the standard of execution as well as citizens' services.

3. **Business platform:** Smart governance initiatives can help businesses get all clearances from a single digital window. In addition, the government can create online forums for exchange of information between various businesses, provide

a platform that can be used by companies to show their innovative work, etc. This online portal may be used for investor meets, bringing in foreign investments to connect with local businesses. A thriving local business means creation of jobs, increased tax collection and better opportunities for citizens.

4. **Tracking the performance of citizens' services:** Automation of key citizen services can help decision makers with key data pointers; e.g., the downtime of a key public utility, the electricity outages, the average time to service a fault, etc, can all be analysed with concrete data. The data for various public utilities can be mapped and tracked with smart automation. The quality of roads, transport facilities, water, electricity and Wi-Fi supply, etc, can be improved with digitisation and smart governance.
5. **Tourism:** Tourism is one of the top revenue generation sources for governments. Promoting tourism creates opportunities for citizens and local merchants. With smart city initiatives, the government can provide tourist interaction services through a portal. Hotel bookings, site visits and grant of visas can also be facilitated through online travel portals. Tourists can use smart city portals for all their queries, feedback and making online reservations. Tourism not only promotes cultural ties but also helps to improve the economic development and prosperity of a city.
6. **Healthcare system:** Smart city projects and digitisation are meant to improve the quality of public health utilities. Efficient governance means proactively responding to queries and health problems of citizens, and engaging with them through digital channels. Digital governance and smart city management is aimed at creating a positive impact in the lives of its citizens.

Blockchain in smart city administration

Blockchain technology, contrary to popular perception, is not merely the basis of the cryptocurrency Bitcoin. This system for carrying out verifications and secure transactions on the Internet promises to revolutionise the management of smart cities. With blockchain, different city services can be efficiently coordinated, integrated and controlled with transparency, keeping citizens' privacy in mind.

The various advantages of using blockchain for governing cities are listed below.

- **Increased transparency and connectivity:** Cities can interconnect using blockchain vertical services, such as mobility, energy or security, through a single, open, accessible, transversal system that is able to exchange data with their inhabitants in real-time.
- **Direct communication:** Blockchain makes it possible for government departments and the public to interact digitally, without the need for intermediaries. This would speed up, for example, bureaucratic procedures at registries, town halls, etc.
- **Integrity of information:** With this technology it is possible to encrypt a file totally or partially in order to share only the part that is of interest, privately, securely and without the risk of it being manipulated by a third party.
- **Efficient management:** Blockchain allows both public and city officials to know the origin and destination of each resource. In addition, the latter can find out how city services are being used without compromising people's privacy.
- **Enhanced security:** Blockchain improves the protection of the personal data collected.
- **Saving energy:** Smart blockchain based contracts make it easier for solar-powered households to automatically trade surplus electricity